Détente means little if it is not reflected in the daily lives of our people. There is no reason why, in 1975, Europeans should not be allowed to marry whom they want, hear and read what they want, travel abroad when and where they want, meet whom they want.

The signatories guaranteed the inviolability of frontiers; territorial integrity of states; peaceful settlement of disputes; non-intervention in internal affairs, avoidance of threat or use of force; sovereign equality; equal rights and self-determination of peoples; and respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms, including the freedom of thought, conscience, religion, or belief. For the first time since the end of the Second World War, the Western states accepted the borders on the continent.

It was hardly surprising that citizens in the GDR took a special interest in clauses on human rights and personal freedoms, given the Accords specifically stated:

Within this framework the participating States will recognise and respect the freedom of the individual to profess and practice, alone or in community with others, religion or belief acting in accordance with the dictates of his own conscience. The participating States on whose territory national minorities exist will respect the right of persons belonging to such minorities to equality before the law, will afford them the full opportunity for the actual enjoyment of human rights and fundamental freedoms and will, in this manner, protect their legitimate interests in this sphere … By virtue of the principle of equal rights and self-determination of peoples, all peoples always have the right, in full freedom, to determine, when and as they wish, their internal and external political status, without external interference, and to pursue as they wish their political, economic, social, and cultural development.